thought we needed another goal. He threw the ball to me just as the final whistle went. I picked it up and kicked it up in the air as high as I could. All the other England players came rushing over towards me. Ashley Cole had been substituted but he came charging across from the England bench, followed by the rest of the squad. I felt so proud, my free-kick taking us through to the World Cup finals. We knew we'd done it even before the announcer came on the PA:

'And the final score from Germany is…'

Suddenly there was silence all round the ground. I get a little shiver when I remember it.

'…Germany 0 Finland 0.'

This roar—I'd never heard anything like it—erupted around Old Trafford and the sound of it followed us back into the dressing room. It was strange: people were going mad, bouncing off the walls, the coaching staff and the subs. Back in the quiet underneath the stand, though, most of the players were just blown out, down even: we knew that we hadn't played well and the heat and the effort of the afternoon hit people hard. I found myself thinking about all the free-kicks I'd missed rather than the one I'd scored. We went back out on the field for a lap of honor and that helped lift us: we could be proud and excited that we would be going to the World Cup Finals after all. I've just one regret about those mad scenes in the sunshine at Old Trafford. Michael Owen was out with a hamstring injury and was analyzing the game for television. We should have got him down to be part of those celebrations: his hat-trick in Munich had been so important, getting us all to where we wanted England to be.

There's a phone just outside the home dressing room at Old Trafford and, when we came back in, the first thing I did was ring Victoria. She was in Italy working, desperate that she'd missed the game. She'd made sure she found out what had happened and now she wanted me to tell her what it felt like. My heart was pounding, adrenaline was still charging round inside me, my mouth was bone dry. Every time I went to speak, my voice cracked and nothing came out. Victoria knows me well enough: the little gasps and croaks were enough for her to understand exactly what was going on at my end of the phone. She may not know all that much about soccer but Victoria knows what it means to people. And she knew what an afternoon like the Greece game meant to me.

Mum and Dad told me afterwards about how the supporters around them